The Striking Force

Smriti Z. Irani, *47*
Union Minister of Women and Child Development, Minority Affairs



CHANDRADEEP KUMAR

ACCOMPLISHMENT
The new POCSO Act ups the punishment for child abuse and child porn, including death. Having Anganwadis adopt experiential learning models

"**SMRITI, WHO...?" IT WAS WITH** a disarming smile at the waiting cameras that Priyanka Gandhi administered that put-down back in 2014, when asked about Smriti Irani going up against Rahul Gandhi in Amethi. Her second stab at a Lok Sabha entry, it was only the sheer daring that saw Smriti come up short again—her debut attempt at giant-killing was against Kapil Sibal in 2004 (she had been drafted into the Rajya Sabha meanwhile, in 2011). She got her own back in 2019: this time, she defeated the Congress's biggest star in his longtime family pocket borough. And this July, she recalled Priyanka's brush-off in a sardonic tweet directed at the Grand Old Party.

Usually, she doesn't take that long with her repartee. Quick, keen-edged and flashing through the air like a samurai katana, she could be seen on TV debates for years taking on all comers, the bigger the better, and all together—slicing off the words of all manner of savants like so many inert bamboo poles, and producing mincemeat. It's that electric felicity with words that saw this lateral entrant with no background in politics level out the playing field by the sheer force of her personality, faster than you could say *Kyunki Saas Bhi Kabhi Bahu Thi*.

The real-life Tulsi was no stoic, suffering *naari*. All the jibes about her degree stood the risk of meeting a rhetorical cut to the carotid. Ascribe it to the fact that a truly eclectic upbringing and exposure—Bengali mother, part-Maharashtrian, part-Punjabi father, convent schooling—made of her a polyglot who could play fast chess in many languages.

As minister, her verbal swordswomanship has shifted mostly to X, where she ranges far beyond her portfolio (and at times fondly recalls her past in the world of glamour). For her work, Smriti channels both her inner anger and empathy. Under her, laws made of iron were forged against child abuse and intimate partner violence. And Anganwadi workers are being trained in play- and activity-based teaching, especially for the differently abled. She also cultivates a special focus on missing/ orphaned children and adoption. ■

–Sonali Acharjee

↘ FAMILY SERIAL Her mother Shibani née Bagchi, whose photos she often Instagrams, is Bengali with an Assam link; father Ajay Malhotra is half-Punjabi, half-Maharashtrian; husband Zubin is Parsi. Daughter Zoish is a chef, son Zohr has a world bronze in kempo

↘ MCTULSI Topped off irregular modelling income doing "jhaadu, pochha, bartan" at McDonald's—to return money borrowed from her dad to enter the 1998 Miss India beauty pageant finals

↘ PASS THE MIKA Before hitting it big, appeared in a Mika song video but turned down a paan masala ad